

1. Unravelling the paradox: meaning, motivation and methodology

A paradox is 'a person or thing conflicting with preconceived notions of what is reasonable or possible ... contrary to accepted opinion'.
(Concise Oxford Dictionary 1983)

A paradox, as the definition above suggests, refers to something that runs contrary to expectations or preconceived ideas. Recurring references to the 'Bangladesh paradox' in the development studies literature are shorthand for the unexpectedness of certain aspects of the country's development experience. Bangladesh has progressed on the social dimensions of development in ways that have not only run contrary to received wisdom in this field but have also confounded the gloomy predictions that accompanied its independence in 1971. Here is one attempt to convey this:

Would you say that a country was likely to reach any of the Millennium Development Goals if it is affected by adverse geographical conditions, has a state apparatus perceived as chronically corrupt, is subject to substantive political instability and is also perceived as moving away from democracy? No, we would not. Yet, Bangladesh, once famously dubbed a test case for development, has made impressive progress in many areas of the MDGs. This is good news. But the really interesting bit is that progress was achieved against the odds, because many would have predicted otherwise. (Asadullah and Savoia 2018)

In fact, the *really* interesting bit is not only that this progress has been achieved against the odds but that it has been both pro-poor and gender-equitable. In a country that had been described as among the very poorest in the world, with a particularly extreme form of patriarchy, this was another aspect of the paradox: 'Bangladesh stands out as the shining new example in South Asia of a poor country achieving impressive gains in gender equality' (World Bank 2008, p.3).

We can distinguish three dimensions to the Bangladesh paradox. There is an economic dimension, the view that a country needs to accumulate a minimum level of wealth before it sees an improvement in the health and wellbeing of its population. Indeed, some scholars adhere to what Sen (1999)

describes as a ‘growth-mediated’ model of social progress, the idea that economic growth is a *necessary* condition for countries to progress on the social front. Yet Bangladesh has performed better on its social development indicators – and on the gender equality of these indicators – than other countries at similar, and even higher levels, of per capita GDP. It is regarded a ‘positive outlier’ on the international stage (Asadullah, Savoia and Mahmud 2014).

There is a political dimension, reflecting the argument that the quality of governance in a country can make a difference, that responsive states can steer ‘policy-supported’ pathways to social progress – sometimes regardless of levels of GDP (Sen 1999). But here, too, Bangladesh has defied expectations. Its state has been widely depicted as corrupt and inefficient, with the politics of clientelism and rent-seeking permeating all levels of government. This has not prevented the country from achieving a pro-poor development trajectory.

Similarly paradoxical, but largely absent from the paradox literature, is that improvements in gender equality began and gathered momentum during a period that saw the steady rise of a particularly orthodox version of Islam in political and public life. The cultural dimension of the paradox derives from the widespread view in the modernisation literature that Islam itself is antithetical to women’s emancipation: it is seen as the ‘other’ of modernity (White 2012). Inglehart and Norris (2003) conclude on the basis of their cross-country analysis of World Values surveys that the ‘true clash of civilizations’ between Islam and the West was not, as suggested by Huntington (1993), over conflicting attitudes to democracy but over conflicting attitudes to gender equality: it was, in other words, a ‘sexual clash of civilizations’ (p.65).

The country’s status as a ‘positive outlier’ in cross-country comparisons of social progress, its reputation as one of the success stories of the Millennium Development Goals, has clearly attracted a great deal of interest within the international development community. But, for longer-standing scholars of Bangladesh, the unexpectedness of the country’s achievements lies less in the comparison with other countries and more in the comparison with its not-so-distant past. They look back to the decade or so following the country’s independence in 1971, when it was ranked as one of the poorest countries in the world, when its uncontrolled population growth rates combined with recurring natural and man-made disasters to wipe out any gains it managed to make, appearing to condemn it to be caught forever in a ‘below poverty level equilibrium trap’.¹ And they want to know: what went right? How did the country manage to pull itself out of these catastrophic conditions and set itself on the road to a moderate degree of success?

In response to these questions, the literature provides elements of a plausible answer. It explains why a dysfunctional state could still promote equitable policies; it refers to the vibrancy of the country’s development NGOs; it notes the role of the donor community that provided generous assistance over the years in exchange for compliance with its advice; it points to the emergence of a dynamic private sector – and it commends the collaboration between these different institutional actors.

But it has largely been a ‘big picture’ story, the ‘view from above’. It tells us a great deal about the beliefs and actions of powerful groups in the society but very little about the role of ordinary people, those who were absent from the established centres of decision-making and largely nameless in the literature. Yet it was the responses of these ordinary people to their changing environment that was the ultimate driving force behind the country’s unexpected progress. It is this missing piece of the story that is related in this book.

This book is therefore about a subject that is of perennial interest in the social sciences: how social change happens. But, more than that, it is a story about how change happens in the face of apparently insurmountable barriers. It retells this story as it has been told so far but it takes the ‘view from below’. And, for reasons that I explain next, it places women’s agency in the processes of change at the heart of the story.

1.1 Women’s agency and the Bangladesh paradox

The origins of my interest in this story go back to the late 1970s, when I was doing my PhD at the London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE). I was trying to explain the high rates of fertility that prevailed in the country at the time and that were widely attributed to cultural irrationality on the part of peasants. As someone trained in economics and registered in the Economics Department, I wanted to find out if an economic rationale revolving around the contributions of children to the household economy compared to their costs might have a role to play. It was not, however, the formal rational choice models of neoclassical economics that I found most persuasive but the approaches taken in economic anthropology, suggesting that culture, institutions and social relationships mediated the costs and benefits of children in different contexts. In South Asia, for instance, anthropologists had pointed out that a strong patriarchal culture that marginalised women in the economy had led to forms of gender discrimination so extreme that they were described as the ‘endangered sex’ (Miller 1983): unlike the rest of the world, female mortality exceeded male almost from birth. In a culture where boys were far more valued than girls, families ended up having more children than they wanted to ensure the survival of a minimum number of sons (Cain, Khanam and Nahar 1979).

Influenced by their approach, I decided I wanted to carry out my own fieldwork and explore these questions for myself. The Economics Department did not encourage primary fieldwork so I shifted to Population Studies and went off to live for 18 months in the village of Amarpur (pseudonym) in Faridpur district. Unfortunately, my training in economics left me with very little idea about how to do ethnographic research. Instead I ended up designing my own surveys to reflect the ideas I had absorbed,² although I believe that my time living in the village for over a year gave me a feel for the rhythm of rural life that I would not have otherwise had and a greater appreciation for hands-on research.

Amarpur was similar to many villages in Bangladesh at the time, not as rich as some, not as poor as many. Women had around seven children by the time they had completed childbearing, the same high rates of fertility that prevailed elsewhere in Bangladesh. My survey data confirmed that sons made a greater economic contribution to their families than daughters for reasons discussed in Chapter 5; daughters appeared to be a net liability. In addition, my survey of married women included a series of questions that allowed me to construct 'preference scales' that separated out their desire for large numbers of children from their preference for sons³ (Kabeer 1986). I will discuss the findings from this early Amarpur research in greater detail in Chapter 9. What is relevant to report at this stage is that they suggested that the high rates of fertility I found in the village were motivated by the desire for sons rather than for large families per se. In other words, they echoed the wider literature on the topic.

After my PhD, I joined the Institute of Development Studies, Sussex. I retained my commitment to field-based research in South Asia, honed my qualitative research skills, and undertook various projects that took me back to the region on a regular basis. I was therefore aware of studies documenting the emergence of what became known as the Bangladesh paradox. An illustration of the paradox was provided by Drèze and Sen (2013) through a comparison of Bangladesh, India and Pakistan, three neighbouring countries in South Asia, using data from 1990 and 2011.⁴ These are presented in Table 1 in Appendix 5, supplemented with information from other sources. Drèze and Sen noted India's near-uninterrupted record on democracy since its independence in 1947, in contrast to extended periods of military rule in both Bangladesh and Pakistan. They also noted that Bangladesh lagged behind both India and Pakistan on the economic front: its per capita GDP was lower throughout this period and its levels of poverty higher.⁵

However, in terms of social indicators, Bangladesh began out behind the other two, but at some point after 1990 it had caught up with them and forged ahead:

- Fertility rates declined in all three countries but, while Bangladesh started out with higher rates than the other countries in 1950, they were 2.2 in 2011 compared to 2.6 in India and 3.4 in Pakistan (Bloom, Canning and Rosenberg 2011; Drèze and Sen 2013).
- Broad-based progress in health services and living standards across the region had led to an increase in overall life expectancy in all three countries. Again, Bangladesh had started out with the lowest life expectancy of the three in 1950 but reported a dramatic increase, overtaking India in 2000 and catching up with Pakistan in 2010 (Bloom, Canning and Rosenberg 2011).
- All three countries had reported higher male life expectancy than female in the 1960s. By 2016, female life expectancy had exceeded

male in all three countries, converging with the pattern that prevailed in most countries. The shift began earlier in Bangladesh and went further. By 2011, life expectancy in Bangladesh was 70 for women and 68 for men; it was 67 and 64, respectively, for India and 66 and 64 in Pakistan.⁶

- The story was similar for infant mortality rates. Countries in the South Asia region reported average rates of 168 per 1000 live births in the early 1950s. They had fallen to 53 by 2010 (Bloom, Canning and Rosenberg 2011) but of the three countries, they fell furthest in Bangladesh (Drèze and Sen 2013). By 2011, its infant mortality rates were 37 per 1000 live births compared to 47 in India and 59 in Pakistan.

The picture on gender differentials in child mortality diverged from what was a pattern of progress, albeit an uneven one, in all three countries. Gender differentials remained high in India, leading to some of the highest levels of excess female mortality in the world and a persisting female deficit in the under-five age group (Alkema et al. 2014; Guilmoto et al. 2018, p.e657).⁷ In addition, evidence began to emerge of a growing resort to female-selective abortion in India, made possible by the introduction of prenatal diagnostic technologies that could detect the sex of the foetus. By ensuring that more sons were born than daughters, parents were able to combine their desire for fewer children with their continued preference for sons. As a result, not only did excess levels of female mortality persist among children but sex ratios at birth began to rise from what were considered ‘normal’ levels of 105 male to 100 female births (which prevailed in much of the world) to levels of 111 by 2011, reflecting the malign new strategy of ‘death before birth’ (Das Gupta and Bhatt 1997; Tong 2022).⁸ We will return to possible explanations for this in the concluding chapter.

There seemed to have been some rise in sex ratios at birth in Pakistan after the 1990s, but by no means as dramatic as that in India (Ritchie and Roser 2019; Zaidi and Morgan 2016). In Bangladesh, on the other hand, gender differentials in infant and child mortality had largely disappeared by 2000, while sex ratios at birth remained remarkably constant at the international norm of 105 males to every 100 females.⁹

This decline in older forms of discrimination against girls in Bangladesh, unaccompanied by a rise in the lethal new forms observed in neighbouring India, strongly suggested that a shift had taken place at some fundamental level in its structures of patriarchy, one that had led to a revaluation of daughters in a culture long characterised by strong son preference.

Intrigued by this possibility, I decided to investigate it as part of a larger research project on gender, work and social change in Bangladesh, a collaboration between IDS and the BRAC Institute of Governance and Development (BIGD) in Bangladesh. The project included Amarpur in a survey of

women from different districts that we carried out in 2008. The project team returned to Amarpur in 2010 to collect life history narratives from men and women from different generations in order to explore their views about sons and daughters. Once again, I will discuss the findings from the later research in Amarpur in greater detail in Chapter 9 but here I highlight some key ones that helped to shape the analysis in this book.

The first key finding, which was reported by both the survey data and qualitative interviews, was that there had been a decline in fertility rates in Amarpur, mirroring the decline that had taken place in the rest of Bangladesh. There had also been a decline in the preference for large families and an even greater decline in the preference for sons. Most men and women now wanted both sons and daughters, with some even expressing a preference for daughters. The life history narratives confirmed the near-universal shift to the norm of small families documented by the survey data. Also echoing the survey data, they confirmed that there had been a marked shift in favour of balanced sex composition of children.

In addition, their narratives provided an account of how life had been in the past and how it was today. The older generation recalled the immense poverty of the early years of independence and the precarious nature of their lives. Men and women across the generations believed that positive social changes had taken place since that period and clearly saw their own actions as part of this change ('keeping up with the changing times'). They did not describe their role in terms of a purely individual cost-benefit analysis, although costs and benefits did enter into their decisions. Instead, changes at the individual level appeared to be bound up with the changes that were taking place at the societal level, changes that were affecting relationships between men and women, parents and children, individuals and communities.

Finally, interspersed throughout the narratives were direct and indirect references to women's agency as one of the forces behind these changes. There seemed to be a widespread belief that women were taking greater control of their lives (almost *too much* control, in the view of some), that they were using their agency to carve out a better deal for themselves and for their children, and that daughters featured prominently in their aspirations in a way that they had not done in the past. Given that those we were speaking to had been brought up to think and behave in ways that were rooted in the long-standing structures of female subordination that characterised Bangladesh, their accounts offered important insights into how women in Amarpur were being able to renegotiate the terms of what had been described as 'among the least negotiable patriarchies in the world' (Goetz 1992, p.12).

These narratives explain the central role given to women's agency in my account of the Bangladesh paradox. In the rest of this chapter, I discuss the wider literature that provides the theoretical rationale for this focus as well as the broader context of my research. I sketch out a conceptual framework that helps to pull together different pieces of this account and draw out

their interconnections. I conclude with a discussion of my methodological approach and a roadmap of the book.

1.2 Gender, economy and demography in the belt of 'classic patriarchy'

Comparative research on the structures of patriarchy since the 1970s has documented systematic regional variations in the organisation of family, kinship and gender relations across the world, a 'geography of gender' (Townsend and Momsen 1987). Of specific relevance to this book is what this research has said about a range of countries stretching from North Africa across the Middle East to the northern plains of South Asia, termed the belt of 'strong' or 'classic' patriarchy (Cain 1984; Kandiyoti 1988). While the countries in question varied considerably in terms of their religions, political regimes and development trajectories, their family and kinship systems had certain features broadly in common, summarised by Caldwell (1978) as 'extended, patrilineal, patrilocal, patriarchal, endogamous and occasionally polygynous' (p.558).

These features gave rise to the forms of gender discrimination that I noted earlier, discrimination so extreme that women in these countries died in larger numbers than men in almost every age group – in marked contrast to the rest of the world, where women generally lived longer than men in different age groups and in the overall population. The results were highly 'masculine' sex ratios in the populations of these countries, ranging anywhere between 106 to 110 or more men to every 100 women compared to the ratios of 100 or fewer men that prevailed elsewhere. Sen (1990a) coined the phrase 'missing women' to refer to the deficit in the number of women that resulted from these lethal forms of discrimination. Estimating it at more than 100 million women globally, he described it as one of the worst human catastrophes of the 20th century.¹⁰

Family and kinship structures in the belt of classic patriarchy stood in contrast with those prevailing in other regions. For instance, the predominant pattern of kinship and descent in South East Asia was bilateral, with rights of inheritance extended to both men and women; there was relative flexibility in post-marital residence; and women retained ties with their natal kin after marriage. There were also far fewer restrictions on their mobility: they were more likely to be active in the labour force, primarily in agriculture and trade, and hence contributed directly to household production. In sub-Saharan Africa as well, while systems of inheritance and marital practice varied across the region, it was possible for women to either inherit or enjoy use rights to land, while high rates of female labour force participation were common.

These studies provided a broad-brush sketch of geographical variations in patriarchal regimes across developing countries. Detailed research from South Asia offered a more disaggregated picture (Dyson and Moore 1983; Miller 1981; Sopher 1980; Visaria 1961; Visaria 1967). It suggested that the region did not constitute a homogenous bloc, that there were variations in

patriarchal regimes within it. In particular, it suggested a north–south pattern to kinship regimes within the Indian context, a pattern so clear that it allowed the country to be divided into two by an east–west diagonal line that followed the contours of the Vindhya hills and the Narmada river valley (Sopher 1980).

Kinship systems north of this divide, referred to as the Indo-Aryan model, displayed many of the features of classic patriarchy, but inflected through the Hindu caste system. The patrilineal system of kinship, which traced descent and inheritance practices through the male child, meant that the gender and paternity of the child were paramount to the reproduction of the patrilineage. Male honour, and the honour of the family, required strict controls over women's sexuality and reproductive behaviour, secluding them within the domestic domain and restricting their participation in the economy.

Caste endogamy, or marriage within the same *jati* (sub-caste) group, ensured the reproduction of the caste hierarchy.¹¹ At the same time, patrilocal marriage together with strict enforcement of kin and village exogamy meant that spouses were unrelated in terms of kinship and that brides left their natal village after marriage to join their husbands' families, often travelling considerable distances to do so. Marriage among caste Hindus was also hypergamous: women married 'upwards' into a socially and ritually superior status family within their caste hierarchy. The inferiority of 'wife-givers' was signified by the payment of dowry, the transfer of wealth from the bride's family to the groom's, at the time of marriage.¹²

These interlocking practices provided powerful incentives in favour of sons, who were central to the transmission of property, the continuation of the patrilineage and the perpetuation of the caste system. They were active in the economy, brought in dowry when they married, lived with or close to their parents, provided support as they grew older and performed the obligatory funeral rites when they died. Daughters were denied property rights and had to be married off at considerable cost, only to move away from their natal village after marriage, with the result that their productive and reproductive labour was lost to parents.

The limited contribution by daughters, the premium placed on female chastity, and the fact that dowry costs tended to rise with age of marriage put pressure on parents to marry them off at an early age. For the husband's family, young brides were advantageous because they could start bearing children from an early age, increasing the probability of producing male heirs. But, from the bride's perspective, the pressure for early and frequent childbearing to produce the sons on which their status within the family so crucially depended led to high levels of fertility accompanied by high levels of maternal mortality.

Kinship systems to the south of this divide, the Indo-Dravidian model, were more flexible with greater diversity of practice. They allowed for bilateral rules of inheritance so that women could also inherit property, and they were characterised by preferred rather than prescribed forms of marriage, with close-kin marriage the ideal form. Marriage could take place close to the natal home and post-marital residence patterns varied considerably. Women generally married into families that were socially and ritually equal; bridewealth was

more common than dowry and marriage expenses were shared between the kin groups of bride and groom. There was less stress on female chastity and fewer controls over women's sexuality and freedom of movement. They were more likely to be active in production outside the home and daughters were as likely as sons to render support to parents as they got older.

As Dyson and Moore (1983) note, these north–south differences gave rise to distinct regional patterns in economic, social and demographic outcomes (Appendix 5, Table 2).¹³ Women's literacy and labour force participation rates were lower in the northern states than in the south; they were more likely to be secluded within the home, were married at younger ages, were less likely to use contraception and reported higher rates of fertility. In addition, female mortality rates exceeded male in most age groups so that sex ratios in their overall population were highly masculine, ranging from 106 to 114 males to every 100 females, compared to ratios ranging from 107 to 97 in the southern states. Using an index to measure son preference, where a value of zero would imply equal preference for sons and daughters, Dyson and Moore (1983) found much stronger son preference in the north, where the value of the index ranged from 20.7 to 31.3, than in the south, where values ranged between 8.9 and 18.4.

While their study focused mainly on empirical material from India, they also attempted to locate their kinship typology within the larger Asia region. They suggested that the north Indian system belonged within the 'West Asian' system, what we described as the belt of classic patriarchy, while the south Indian one overlapped with the South East Asian constellation. In other words, the Vindhya–Narmada divide also represented the 'great divide' between two larger sociocultural systems (Miller 1981, p.24).

Dyson and Moore located Sri Lanka within the south Indian kinship system because there was very little evidence of excess female mortality, while Pakistan, with its high fertility rates and excess female mortality, appeared closer to the north Indian system. The eastern regions presented more of a challenge. The smaller states of India's north-eastern promontory were largely populated by indigenous ethnic minorities, 'tribal' peoples, with very different kinship practices to either of the two main paradigms. They clearly represented a distinctive cultural and demographic regime.

The eastern states of Orissa, Bihar and West Bengal, on the other hand, appeared to represent intermediate regimes. They had some elements in common with both the main systems but differed considerably from each other, despite geographical proximity. The prevalence of cross-cousin marriage in Bihar seemed to place it in the south Indian system, although its strong son preference and excess female mortality among children was more characteristic of classic patriarchy. There was greater consistency between kinship and demographic patterns within Orissa and West Bengal. Their marital patterns (cross-cousin marriage in the former case and village endogamy in the latter), lower levels of fertility, weak or absent levels of excess female mortality and lower son preference together suggested closer affinity to the south Indian model.

Bangladesh proved even harder to place. Though Bangladesh and West Bengal had made up the united province of Bengal in pre-partition India, shared

a common ethno-linguistic identity, and might be expected to display strong similarities, Dyson and Moore believed that Bangladesh had stronger affinities with the northern kinship and demographic regime. They based this on the rareness of cross-cousin marriage (associated with the south Indian model), early age of marriage among women, their isolated and vulnerable position after joining their husbands' kinship group and high rates of fertility and child mortality (all associated with the north Indian model). They also noted that there had been a shift some time in the second half of the 20th century from the practice of bridewealth at marriage, common among Muslims in the subcontinent, to the practice of dowry, which characterised the north Indian model, suggesting a strengthening of the association with this model. They did, however, notice some uncertainty in the existing literature about whether there was excess female mortality among children in Bangladesh, a hallmark of the north Indian demographic regime. This led them to conclude that the 'situation [was] complicated and by no means analogous in all respects' (p.52).

As Dyson and Moore point out, differences in aspects of kinship and demography between Hindu-majority West Bengal and Muslim-majority Bangladesh appeared to foreground religious differences as part of the explanation. However, they note that the consensus among scholars was that regional variations in kinship systems, demographic regimes and sex ratios across the South Asian subcontinent were of longer historical standing, predating the arrival of Islam on the subcontinent. This suggested that regional differences between the northern Aryan and the southern Dravidian cultural formations were more plausible explanations of the variations in demographic outcomes than religious differences. The practice of Islam varied considerably across the regional divide and appeared to reflect localised social practices (Mandelbaum 1970).

This view was borne out by Miller (1983), who found that juvenile sex ratios differed considerably between Bangladesh and Pakistan, the two Muslim-majority countries on either side of the north Indian plains – but closely resembled the Hindu-majority states in India that neighboured them. The preponderantly male child sex ratios in Pakistan were similar to those of the neighbouring north-western Indian states of Rajasthan and Punjab, while the more egalitarian sex ratios reported in Bangladesh resembled those of the neighbouring state of West Bengal.¹⁴ So, while the influence of religion may have played some role in explaining the differences between West Bengal and Bangladesh noted by Dyson and Moore, these differences were more likely to reflect their different histories of migration and settlement than their religion (discussed in the next chapter).

1.3 Gender, agency and patriarchal regimes

Differences in gender and kinship regimes were clearly relevant to explanations of regional variations in patterns of gender discrimination, but

these explanations also contained some interesting propositions about the implications of different regimes for women's agency and its role in mediating demographic outcomes. For instance, Dyson and Moore suggest that, within south Indian kinship systems, women's greater mobility and freedom to participate in the labour force meant that daughters constituted less of a dependency burden on their parents and wives on their husbands. This, they suggest, was an important factor in explaining the more equal treatment meted out to female members of the family.

Sen (1990b) discusses the issue of women's agency in his work on 'missing women'. He points to the positive correlation between women's economic activity rates and their survival chances relative to men across Africa and Asia. He suggests two pathways through which the correlation might reflect causality. One pathway worked at the societal level. In regions where women customarily worked outside the household, their contributions to the household were more socially visible, more likely to be recognised by family and society and hence more likely to entitle them to a fairer share of household resources. By contrast, in societies where women were confined to domestic activities, where their contributions were less visible and less valued, gender discrimination from an early age was likely to be the norm.

A second causal pathway operated at household level, with women's contributions to household livelihoods differentiating the degree of voice and influence they were able to exercise within their households. Women's engagement in paid activity, their contribution to household finances, was likely to increase their ability to negotiate a more egalitarian distribution of its resources. Important to note here is the assumption that mothers would be less likely than fathers to discriminate against daughters.¹⁵

Drèze and Sen (1995) explored these ideas in greater detail in the context of India. Controlling for the regional divide in patriarchal regimes, they found that districts with higher levels of female economic activity and literacy reported lower fertility rates and lower female disadvantage in child survival. Female literacy also reduced overall child mortality. Male literacy rates reduced the female disadvantage in child survival but the effect was much smaller and they had no effect on under-five mortality or fertility rates. In other words, while variations in patriarchal structures contributed to variations in the pattern of demographic outcomes, a societal effect indicated by the significant effect of regional variables, variations in women's individual agency also had an impact on these outcomes, independent of structures.

A somewhat different approach to the analysis of women's agency and its implications for reproductive behaviour can be found in Kandiyoti (1988). She suggests that different regimes could be seen as embodying distinct 'rules of the game' or 'patriarchal bargains', which spelt out the structure of constraints and opportunities within which women and men could exercise agency. While most women in most contexts had an interest in securing their place in their societies, and minimising threats to it, the agency permitted to them and the strategies they could pursue reflected

the possibilities embodied in these context-specific gendered constraints. They were consequently likely to deal with the implications of patriarchal power in their lives, to 'bargain with patriarchy', very differently within the belt of classic patriarchy compared to the strategies pursued by women in less tightly controlled patriarchal regimes.

For instance, studies from the African context testified to the considerable degree of autonomy displayed by women in their efforts to safeguard their own interests. Their access to property of their own and their ability to engage in independent economic activities seemed to have given rise to a greater willingness to engage in open forms of conflict with those in authority. Within families, they prioritised their own farms and trading enterprises to reduce their dependence on, and obligations to, husbands and they deserted their marriages when conditions became intolerable. In the public domain, they were willing to resist government policies that went against their interest. This degree of independence meant that they had no reason to favour sons over daughters.

This presented a stark contrast to women's behaviour within classic patriarchy. Here women strove to adhere as far as possible to the restrictive societal norms defining their behaviour: they avoided mobility in the public domain, deferred to male authority within the household and sought to produce as many sons as possible to assure their place within their husband's patrilineage. The risks and uncertainties associated with women's dependence on men within classic patriarchy created powerful incentives for son preference and high levels of fertility.

These studies provide the outlines of the hypothesis about women's agency and reproductive outcomes that underpins the analysis in this book. Its starting premise is that the overarching structures of patriarchy in a society determine the value given to its women as evidenced by the degree of equality they enjoy. Those that embody greater freedom for women are also more likely to give them greater value because they are able to participate in a wide range of roles within the economy and make substantial contributions to household production.

Within the restrictive context of classic patriarchy, such as the one that characterises Bangladesh, the hypothesis suggests two different, though mutually compatible, routes through which greater gender equality might emerge:¹⁶

- Through shifts in patriarchal structures which allow an expansion of the range of productive roles that women are able to play, reduce their dependency status and promote their revaluation at societal level – and the revaluation of daughters within the family.
- Through the increased bargaining power that accrues to individual women within their households as a result of expanded economic opportunities, which they are able to use to achieve a more gender-egalitarian distribution of household resources.

1.4 Conceptualising continuity and change

The narratives I heard in Amarpur persuaded me that there was a story to be told about the Bangladesh paradox from a different standpoint to that taken in the literature so far. It would focus on how the larger drivers of change identified in this literature were experienced and acted on as they unfolded in the lives of ordinary people and how their experience and agency helped to shape the course of change. And it would focus on women's experience and agency as the central core of the story. But it was clear that individual responses could not be understood independently of the context in which they took place. There was a path dependence to the change narratives we heard in Amarpur: they bore strong traces of the past because past constraints had set the parameters within which subsequent change evolved.

There was thus a twofold analytical challenge to unravelling the Bangladesh paradox. It required an explanation for the conditions that prevailed at the start of the paradox and why they had appeared to scholars of that period to be so intransigent. And it required an explanation of the pathways through which change *did* take place in subsequent years.

This dual challenge in turn needed a conceptual framework that could bring its two strands together in a coherent way. Theories of practice in the fields of anthropology and sociology provide a promising way forward, starting with Giddens's structuration theory, which sought to integrate the two dominant social science traditions of structural determinism and methodological individualism (1979). Structuralist traditions focus primarily on the larger social forces in a society that are considered to govern human behaviour. One strand of these traditions highlights the cultural systems that prevail in particular contexts. Some of the early literature on gender discrimination in Bangladesh, for instance, explained it in terms of customs, beliefs and role expectations rooted in Bengali Muslim culture (Aziz 1979; Aziz and Maloney 1985). The other strand is concerned with the material arrangements of a society and their impact on identities and interests. In the Bangladesh context, for instance, this tradition focused on its agrarian power structure, on the 'intermediate' character of its governance regime and on its patriarchal kinship system.

A diametrically opposite view is to be found within voluntarist traditions, which portray human behaviour as the expression of individuals' tastes and preferences, subject to the resources they have at their disposal. This is, of course, the dominant view within mainstream neoclassical economics. An early example of this in the Bangladesh literature can be found in Khandker (1987), who sought to demonstrate that women's labour force participation was not 'inflexibly fixed by local custom' (p.24) as claimed by cultural explanations but could be explained by standard economic variables such as education, land and livestock.

Structuration theory brings these traditions together in a mutually interdependent relationship: structures constrain human agency but are

simultaneously produced by human agency. The actions of individuals are seen to be guided by, and operating within, the range of possibilities generated by the cultural beliefs and material arrangements of their society. Because their conduct is constrained in this way, it generally serves to reproduce these beliefs and arrangement – but not invariably. There is scope for human conduct to modify, destabilise and even transform aspects of structure. In the rest of this section, I bring together the key building blocks of structuration theory – structure, practice and agency – to sketch out a conceptual framework that will help to make sense of the different processes of continuity and change that feature in this book.

Conceptualising continuity

Structure

The concept of structure refers to those aspects of the social world that impose patterns on, or ‘structure’, other aspects of this world, including the behaviour of human actors. As Sewell (1992) points out, it has both virtual and real dimensions. The virtual dimension refers to the systems of norms, beliefs and conventions, or cultural schemas, which provide a pattern to social life. Structures in this sense do not exist concretely in time and space but are lodged in the human brain and the collective consciousness of social groups.

These cultural schemas become ‘real’ through the concrete arrangements that they give rise to. They demarcate society into different institutional domains that are organised around their own internal logic – familial reproduction, the production of subsistence and surplus, the governance of communities. They classify people into different groups on the basis of differentially valued identities. And they distribute valued resources between these groups. The unequal nature of these classifications and distributions gives rise to a social order in which privileged groups have both a stake in the existing order and the resources to ensure its reproduction.

Resources are conceptualised in ways that capture what makes them valuable in different societies. Bourdieu (1977) distinguishes between ‘resources’ as latent possibilities of different kinds and ‘capital’ as the mobilisation of these possibilities in purposeful activities: the pursuit of needs, interests and goals. What is valued about resources, in other words, is what they enable people to achieve, their implications for agency. Material resources are, of course, the most familiar within the literature – I have cited land and livestock as examples from the early Bangladesh literature. Today, as Bangladesh strives to become a modern, market-oriented society, new kinds of material resources, such as institutional finance and digital technology, have taken on greater significance.

Human resources refer to the physical and mental capabilities embodied in human being, their bodily capacity, skills, education and knowledge. Also widely recognised in the literature is the importance of social resources, networks of relationships, which spell out claims and obligations between people and can be mobilised in the pursuit of objectives. Later chapters will discuss

the importance of social relationships in Bangladesh for the kinds of agency people were able to exercise: horizontal ones based on family and kinship, as well as vertical ones based on power and patronage. Poverty and helplessness in Bangladesh, it has been observed, was as much about being 'poor in people', having no one to turn to in times of trouble, as it was about being poor in property (McCarthy 1967).

Finally, practice theory gives central role to symbolic capital, the status, prestige and respect associated with position in the social order. While resources more generally determine the courses of action available to groups of people, symbolic resources bestow certain groups with the authority to interpret cultural norms, to determine which courses of action are considered acceptable and which transgress normative boundaries. They have the power, in other words, to constrain and enable the actions of others in ways that reproduce the social order and their own privileged position within it.

Practice

The norms, beliefs and conventions of a society operate at the everyday level through the various bundles of activities that define and differentiate the domains of social life. They are embedded within these activities through the generalised, taken-for-granted procedures that are routinely invoked by people as they go about their daily business without much reflection and thought. While the concept of practice could refer, in principle, to anything that people do, practice theory is concerned with issues of power and domination. It tends to focus on actions that are bound up, intentionally or otherwise, with the processes of structuration through which the inequalities of the social order are produced and reproduced (Ortner 1984). For instance, while the social conventions of Bengali culture that prescribe the most auspicious time of day to cut one's hair and nails (see Chapter 3) may be intriguing phenomena, they are far less consequential for processes of structuration than conventions about how food is distributed within the family and who is given priority.

Shove, Pantzer and Watson (2012) suggest that we can conceptualise social practices as constituted by specific combinations of elements – material elements, relevant knowledge and the social meanings attributed to the practice. It is the extent to which these constituent elements remain fused in repeated enactments over time that gives continuity to social practice. Equally, it is the loosening of one or more of these elements, their incorporation into other kinds of activities, that brings about change.

Social practices do not exist in isolation but are interwoven with each other over time to create the systemic character of everyday life. For instance, the patriarchal norms that assign primary responsibility for domestic work to women in Bangladesh and shape how they carry it out within their households also govern the market-based activities of men. Unequal access to market-based activities, in turn, feeds into domestic practices, determining whose claim on household food and other resources will be given priority.

Agency

Agency, the capacity for thought and action embodied in social actors, is the third central concept within structuration theory, linking the routinised performance of social practice with the subjectivity of the actor. Social actors enact social practices, rather than simply pursuing their own random and idiosyncratic preferences, because they do not, and cannot, exist as isolated individuals; they are always persons enmeshed in social relations that require them to behave in certain ways. Bourdieu's concept of habitus has been very influential in practice theory as a way of capturing how structural principles take root in individual subjectivities so that people adhere routinely and largely unconsciously to the social conventions that govern the conduct of daily life. Habitus describes how actors internalise the culturally defined and materially organised structures of their external world in the form of 'durable dispositions', propensities to think, feel and act in ways that accord with the structures that produced them and thus reproduce them over time.

The concept of habitus goes beyond mental schemas that shape individual subjectivities to also encompass embodied ways of being in the world, influencing how people occupy spaces, through their gestures, posture and deportment in the different domains of their lives. Bourdieu talks about the 'hauteur of the aristocrat' and 'the stance of the peasant' by way of examples, but anyone who has done fieldwork in the sexually segregated context of Bangladesh will be only too aware of the embodied nature of habitus in the ease with which men inhabit public space and the contrasting discomfort that characterises women, their efforts to dress and conduct themselves in public so as to deflect attention from themselves as far as possible.

Habitus becomes part of individual subjectivities through experiences over the life course, with the early formative years having a particularly powerful effect. People who share a given social position and face similar objective conditions of existence are likely to share certain similarities in their habitus, in how they think and feel about the social world, what they expect of others and what is expected of them. So, while individual history is an important element in the formation of habitus, so too is the collective history of the family and social groups of which the individual is member. And inasmuch as individuals simultaneously belong to different social groups – in the Bangladesh context, groups are organised by gender, class, religion and ethnicity – these intersecting identities and experiences are likely to be internalised as core aspects of their habitus.

Conceptualising change

As Sewell points out, the conceptualisation of structures within practice theory shares the reproductive bias of structuralist theories more generally since the point of the concept is to explain the durability of certain aspects of social life. This does not necessarily rule out scope for agency to be incorporated

into the performance of practice. So, while habitus structures the range of possibilities perceived to be available in relation to certain structures, demarcating a realm of unquestioned routine, habit and tradition, the realm of what Bourdieu refers to as doxa, social actors are still able to engage in purposive forms of agency within its limits, to interpret custom and convention rather than mechanically following it.

However, many do not think that this formulation goes far enough to overcome reproductive bias since the change envisaged is limited to ways of acting, thinking and feeling that are consistent with customs and conventions. This has led Ortner to pose a more general version of the research question that informs this book: *'the question of how actors who are so much the product of their own social and cultural contexts can ever come to transform the conditions of their own existence – except by accident?'* (1989, p.14, my italics).

McLeod (2005) suggests that space for more intentional forms of change can be opened up by allowing for a less tightly presumed relationship between external realities and internalised constraint, thereby allowing scope for improvisation, creativity, reflectiveness and emotions, particularly in the face of unanticipated events of life. Periods of social instability, for instance, are likely to see gaps emerge between internalised dispositions and the social world in which they evolved; patterns of behaviour are likely to become more irregular, to depart from previous social practice. At lower levels of analysis, there are likely to be events that are exceptional, crises, 'blips' in the system, when circumstances require more reflective and intentional forms of agency than is customary (Elder-Vass 2007, p.329).

In addition, the habitus that people acquire in their childhood may be attenuated or modified through changes that occur in the course of their lives, as they grow up and deal with events and experiences their childhood did not prepare them for (McNay 1999). And, as societies become more differentiated, as more ways of earning a living become available, as more ways of learning become possible, the habitus also becomes more open to cross-cutting influences.

Returning to Ortner's question about how change can come about other than accidentally, I want to focus in the rest of this section on what the literature tells us about the different kinds of agency that women who are indeed 'very much the product of their own social and cultural context' might exercise to transform the conditions of their existence and what might motivate them to do so. This provides a useful springboard for a book that is interested in the possibilities for agency available to women in the face of an oppressive patriarchy.

Ortner (2006, p.6) suggests that we can place different manifestations of agency along a spectrum conceptualised in terms of psychological depth of power, its 'pervasiveness or invasiveness' and the scope for intentionality and consciousness – locating unquestioning conformity to social norms at one end of the spectrum and more intentional forms of action along the rest of it. We can also distinguish between different kinds of intentionality.

For instance, Huang (2020) cites a woman in her Bangladesh study who spoke of the different kinds of dreams that women had: 'small dreams' that did little to change their situation, a woman's dream that her husband would bring her back a cooker when he returned from the city, and the 'big dreams' of those who sought to transform the conditions of their existence, women who cultivated a strong sense of self, a directed sense of agency.

Conceptualisations of habitus that stress the deeply 'invasive' nature of power belong at the structurally driven end of the spectrum. For instance, Sen's idea of adaptively formed preferences describes compliance with social norms as the behaviour of those who are 'habituated to inequality, may be unaware of the possibilities of social change, may be hopeless about upliftment of objective circumstances of misery, may be resigned to fate' (1990b, p.127).

Alternatively, women may conform unquestioningly to patriarchal cultures because they do not consider them unjust. They grew up within these cultures, acquired their gendered sense of self through their practices, and they have dreams that can be realised within the limits imposed by them. As Abu-Lughod (2002) argues, Western feminist critiques of patriarchal norms that privilege women's freedom and liberation may have relevance in particular historical or cultural situations but it is possible that different desires, aspirations and capacities shape the subjectivities of women with other histories and cultures. The values of their own culture, such as closeness of family or the cultivation of piety, may have greater meaning for these women: 'We must consider that they might be called to personhood, so to speak, in a different language' (p.788).

Habitus may also ensure conformity by structuring women's interests to give them a stake in upholding the status quo. As Kandiyoti (1988) notes, young brides within the belt of classic patriarchy have a stake in producing and valuing sons at the expense of daughters since their status in their husband's family is dependent on this. Whatever hardships and deprivation they might experience as subservient daughters-in-law will be eventually be superseded when their sons get married and they are able to exercise the control and authority that inheres in the position of mothers-in-law:

The cyclical nature of women's power in the household and their anticipation of inheriting the authority of senior women encourages a thorough internalization of this form of patriarchy by women themselves. (p.279)

A less mentally invasive understanding of power in social life can be found in the work of theorists like Scott (1990). This suggests that women may be aware of the injustice of their situations, perhaps even of the existence of alternative possibilities, but their ability to bring about change is constrained by the sanctions that such efforts will bring in their wake: dissent is costly. But, like most oppressed groups, they may have their own strategies, the 'weapons

of the weak, to win tacit gains or simply to allow the expression of discontent in ways that are relatively safe.

The feminist literature provides many examples of these hidden expressions of rebellion: folk tales, provocative or mocking songs, intrusive noise, disapproving silence, sexually irreverent discourse and taunts (Abu-Lughod 1990; Agarwal 1994; Jackson 2012). As Abu-Lughod points out, when women live in the sexually segregated worlds of classic patriarchy, they are able to use 'secrets and silences to their advantage' (p.43), to cover for each other, colluding to hide knowledge from male authority.

Feminist theories of bargaining and negotiation spell out a third form of agency. This is not 'bargaining' in the structural sense used by Kandiyoti but the more individual forms that come into play when women are sufficiently dissatisfied with the prevailing order that they seek ways of influencing social practices but do so within normative boundaries that do not jeopardise relationships they need or value (Agarwal 1997; Kabeer 2000). This is a conceptualisation that acknowledges greater scope for reflexivity on the part of individual women, but also the need for continued caution. It is exemplified in the strategies of 'wielding and yielding' that Villareal talks about in her study of women in rural Mexico, of making concessions in order to gain concessions in return (1994, p.28).

Where women have few material resources of their own to bargain with, they must draw on the less tangible resources at their disposal to bring about desired changes. Most often we find that they deploy a cultural resourcefulness that seeks to reinterpret and modify discursive boundaries between acceptable and unacceptable behaviour in ways that expand the forms of agency permitted to them. There are limits to the change that can be brought about through discursive strategies alone, given the resilience of material constraints (Bourdieu 1998) but, when these reinterpretations are reflective of, and made possible by, openings and cracks in the 'harder' structures of material and political life, they can serve to 'derail' practice, to become one way in which change becomes embedded in new discourses and new sets of meanings (Nicolini 2012).

The different kinds of agency discussed so far all seek to avoid any form of confrontation that might jeopardise women's claims within the family and their place in the social order. But agency can also take the form of overt departures from accepted practice, the open defiance of those in authority. Such resistance is likely to carry very high costs, particularly in regimes of classic patriarchy in which women are likely to be outcasted for attempts to do so. So what might lead women in these contexts to take such risks?

At the level of consciousness, it is most likely to be motivated by circumstances that open up a gap between what they had been led to expect in exchange for their compliance with social expectations and the reality they are confronted with, by the heightened sense of injustice that this brings. But such awakening of consciousness is not always sufficient on its own to give

them the courage or desperation to act if their actions plunge them into even more desperate circumstances.

I will be exploring examples of open resistance to the patriarchal order in the course of this book but I will note here that it was most often made possible by women's access to new kinds of resources that helped to break how far they would fall. Individual women were able to access new material resources through the external agency of government, markets and civil society that allowed them to contemplate actions that would have been previously inconceivable. Groups of women were able to engage in more organised forms of collective action when it became possible for them to build 'chosen' social networks that acknowledged their grievances and supported their actions, acknowledgement and support that they rarely found within the 'given' social relationships they were born or had married into.

1.5 Road map and methodology

This book sets out to address the twofold analytical challenge of unravelling the Bangladesh paradox that I laid out earlier: to explain both the apparently immutable structural conditions that defined the early stages of the paradox and the unexpected processes of change that took place subsequently. If the first part of the story is concerned with the structural aspects of structuration theory, their reproduction through social practice, the latter part focuses on the agency aspect, the transformation of structures through the medium of changing practice.

Strictly speaking, I am defining the start of the paradox as the period following the country's independence in 1971. It was the grim conditions that prevailed at that time that provided the base line against which later progress was measured. But, in order to analyse how these conditions came into existence and to explain the immutability ascribed to them, I needed to examine what had happened before, to go back into the country's history.

In his book on the history of Bangladesh, Van Schendel (2009) distinguishes between three types of historical process that overlap with each other and continue to play a significant role in contemporary Bangladesh. The first type relates to the very-long-term processes that explain how, over millennia, the forces of history and geography helped to shape the delta region that later became Bangladesh. The second type focuses on the last few centuries, when these longer-term processes interacted with middle-range ones, particularly those associated with foreign rule. And, finally, there are the contemporary historical processes that deal with the decades preceding and following Bangladesh's emergence as an independent nation.

Chapter 2 of this book uses a compressed account of Van Schendel's first two phases to narrate the early history of the region, the particularities of its history and geography that shaped the contours of the country that became Bangladesh. It discusses the waves of rulers who came in search of wealth and